



Jean Louis Hardy

The Laws of Change.

381 principles for becoming the change agent.

Preview edition. The opening and Root One of fourteen.



**Nobody reads a
toolbox from left to
right.**

So do not read this book that way either.

Before you start

How this book works

And how to read it without ruining it.

Most books are built like a long speech at a wedding. You sit through all of it, in order, and you are not allowed to leave until the cake. This one is built like a toolbox. You open it because the sink is leaking.

So relax. You do not have to finish this book. You have to use it.

One idea, said at four sizes

The whole book is one idea. You have one job, and that job is to close the gap between where things are and where they should be. That is true of a company, a marriage, a waistline, and a Tuesday.

Everything after that is the same idea at a smaller size, the way a map can show you the country, then the state, then the town, then the street. One job. Nine foundations. Fourteen roots. Three hundred eighty-one principles. We start big and work down. If you stop after ten pages you will still leave with the whole book in your pocket. You will just be missing the street names.

Read it slowly. I mean it.

Each principle is short on purpose. It is a seed, not a lecture. The famous book is called *Think and Grow Rich*. It is not called *Skim and Grow Rich*. You could sit on one principle for a week, and that would be the right speed. The reader who finishes this in a weekend has won a race nobody else was running.

Ask one question of every page

How does this apply? That is the only question. A page may talk about marketing and be secretly about your marriage. A page about a bridge may fix your Monday meeting. The principles do not care which room of your life you carry them into.

Start with your gap, not with page one

Before you read further, write two sentences. Where are you now? Where do you want to be? Be honest about the first and specific about the second. Then read with that gap in your hand. The book gets about ten times more interesting when it is about you, which, as a rule, is true of most things.

Look at the picture first

Every principle comes with a drawing, and the drawings all speak one small language. A solid dot is where you are. It is solid because it exists. An open circle is where you want to be. It is open because it does not exist yet. Red is the gap between them. Gray is everything holding the situation in place.

Then comes a name, so you can remember it. One line, so you can repeat it. A true story, because people forget arguments and

remember stories. And a move, which is the thing to actually do. The stories are real and they have been checked. I recommend this standard to the whole genre.

A word about the word law

I call these the Laws of Change, and I owe you some honesty about that. Some of them are laws in the strict sense. They are measured, they predict, and they bill you whether or not you agree. Some are patterns, which are real but have exceptions. And some are counsel, which is old wisdom no instrument can measure and which, for the purpose of living a life, is worth more than most laws.

Bet the company on a law. Bet a test on a pattern. Bet your character on counsel. And if you disagree with a page, wonderful. Test it. The answer is in the test, not in your head, and not in mine either.

Where these came from

I did not invent most of what is in here. Most of what works is old. My part was to gather it, put it in plain words, and tie every piece to the one job. The full version of each principle, with the person it came from, lives in the complete book, which is open to members of our research group.

One last thing

You picked up a book about closing gaps, which means you can see one. Take that as a compliment. A gap is what it looks like when a person can picture something better than what is in front

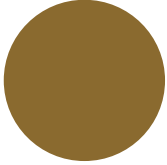
of them. Cows do not have this problem.

You are not behind. You are someone with a destination, and that already puts you ahead of most of the traffic.

Turn the page. Let's find out where you are standing.

The map

The book at four sizes



1 job

Close the gap between where things are and where they should be.



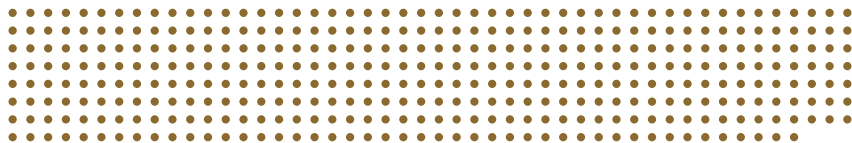
9 foundations

The ground everything else stands on.



14 roots

Each one a single sentence about how the world works.



381 principles

The street names. One short page each.

Every principle grows from one of these

1	The Gap	Everything has a current state and a desired state	18
2	Natural Law	Reality behaves the same way whether or not you agree	35
3	Compounding	Time compounds every cause	21
4	The Instrument	The human instrument is fallible. Correct for it.	21
5	Value	Value is a specific gap, closed	16
6	Wealth	Wealth is made by closing gaps for others	13
7	Mastery	Mastery is evolved, not claimed	14
8	Outside the Crowd	Truth is seen from outside the crowd	20
9	The Test	The answer is in the test, not in your head	33
10	Resonance	Communication is resonance, not volume	31
11	The Inner Gap	The biggest gap to close is your own	46
12	Becoming	You are becoming, not being	27
13	The Team	Nothing great is built alone	30
14	The Arena	Power is a game being played on you. Know its laws.	56

The number on the right is how many principles each root holds. This draft carries the first root in full.



Root 1 of 14

The Gap

Everything has a current state and a desired state.

Root one. 18 principles.

Change is closer to geometry than to mystery

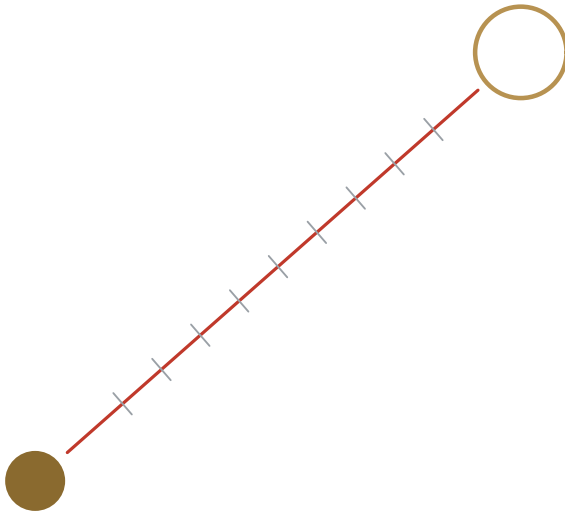
There is a point where things stand, a point where they should stand, and a distance between the two. That is the whole diagram.

Most of what people call being stuck is not a shortage of effort. It is two blurry points and a great deal of jogging in place. You cannot close a distance you have not measured, between a start you will not admit to and a finish you have not named.

The eighteen principles in this root run the full crossing. Name the far side. Be honest about the near side. Do the arithmetic. Draw the map. Plan for the day it goes wrong. And write down what you are building, so that it copies correctly.

When a change agent gets lost, the way back is always the same. Restate the two points, measure the distance again, and take the next step that makes it smaller.

1



Change is the distance between two states.

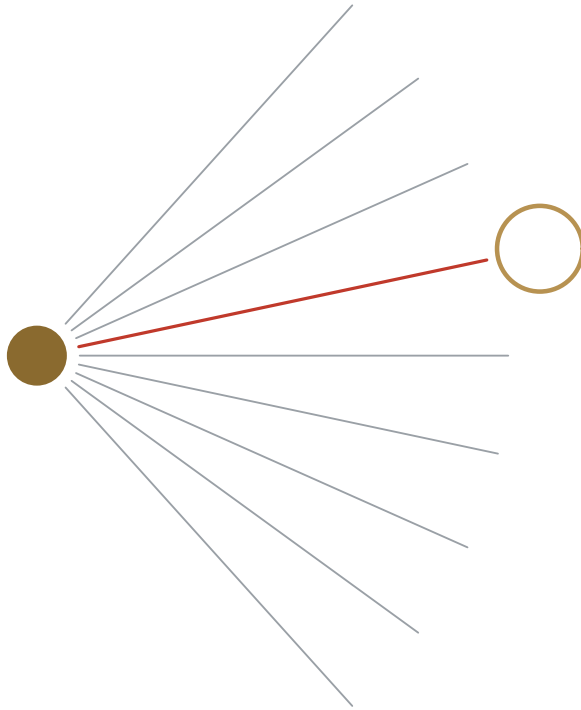
The Gap

In the late 1980s, two crews started digging toward each other under the English Channel, one from England and one from France. They could not see each other. They could not wave. What they had was two very exact points and a lot of mud in between. When they broke through in December 1990, the two tunnels were off by about a foot sideways and three inches up and down.

Nobody on that project was waiting to feel inspired. They had a start, a finish, and a way to measure. That is all change is. It is not an event, a mood, or a Monday. It is a distance.

The move. Before you touch anything, write two sentences. Where is this now? Where does it need to be? Then judge everything you do by one test: did the gap get smaller?

2



An unnamed gap cannot be closed.

Name the Destination

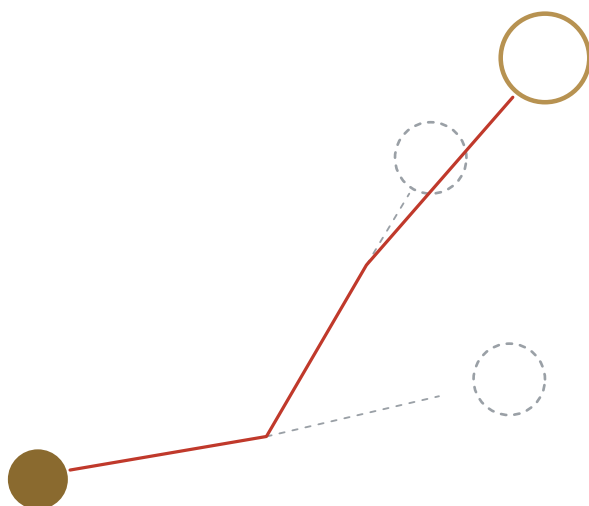
In 1714 the British government did something governments rarely do. It said exactly what it wanted. Twenty thousand pounds to anyone who could fix a ship's position at sea to within half a degree. Not 'improve navigation.' Half a degree.

A carpenter named John Harrison spent decades building clocks against that one number. In 1761 his fourth clock sailed to Jamaica and arrived, eighty-one days later, five seconds wrong.

You will travel through life whether or not you pick a destination. The only question is whether you chose where you end up. So the first question is never 'What should we do?' It is 'What exactly do you want?'

The move. Write the desired state down before any work begins. If it would not fit on a prize poster, it is not named yet.

3



Set one now. You may move it later.

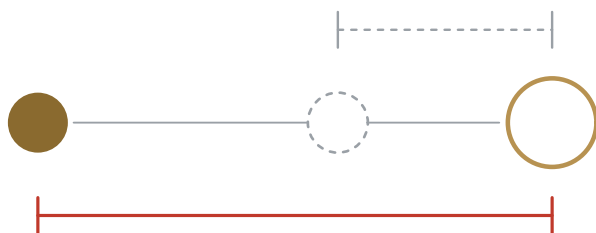
A Target Beats No Target

People wait for the perfect goal the way they wait for the perfect morning to start jogging. Fridtjof Nansen did not wait. In 1893 he froze his ship into the Arctic ice on purpose, betting the current would carry it across the North Pole. It did not. The drift ran too slow and too far south. So in 1895 he got off the ship and went north by sled, and beat the record by nearly three degrees.

A wrong target took him farther north than anyone on record. No target would have taken him to a pleasant evening at home. You can steer a moving car. You cannot steer a parked one, though many meetings have tried.

The move. Stuck hunting for the right goal? Pick a provisional one today. You are allowed to move it.

4



**Measure the gap from the truth,
not the story.**

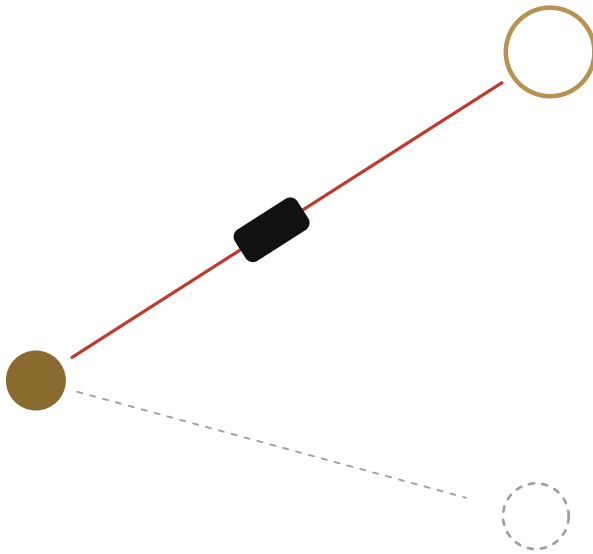
Stand Where You Stand

In January 1909 Ernest Shackleton stood 97 miles from the South Pole. He had walked for months to get there, and every instinct a human being owns was telling him he was nearly done. Instead he counted the food, counted the miles back, planted a flag, and turned around. All four men reached the ship alive.

That is what an honest current state looks like. It is not pessimism. It is arithmetic done without flattering yourself. A plan built from a pretend starting point closes a gap that does not exist, which is a great deal of work for no gap at all.

The move. Before you prescribe anything, look at the real numbers, the real habits, the real situation. The scale is not insulting you. It is giving you directions.

5



People only move toward what they already want.

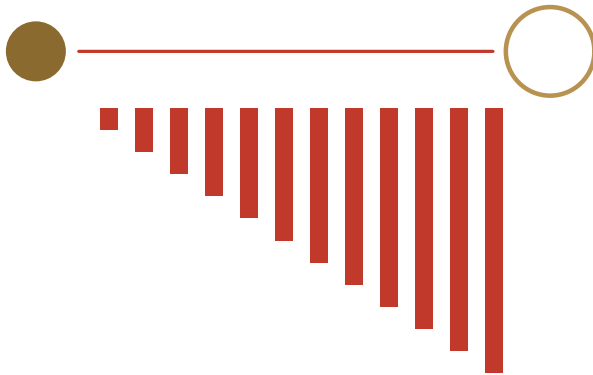
Sell the Trip They Want

From 1915, a London railway published a yearly guide called Metro-land. It did not advertise trains. It advertised a house with a garden in the countryside and a quick ride into the city. The season ticket simply came with the house. Ticket sales at some stations rose more than seven hundred percent in the 1920s.

Nobody in history has wanted a train ticket. People want to be somewhere. The same is true of your proposal, your product, and your advice to your teenager. Offer a road to a place they never asked to go, and no amount of persuasion will save you.

The move. Get the destination in their own words first. Then show your idea as the vehicle on that exact route.

65



Doing nothing is the most expensive option.

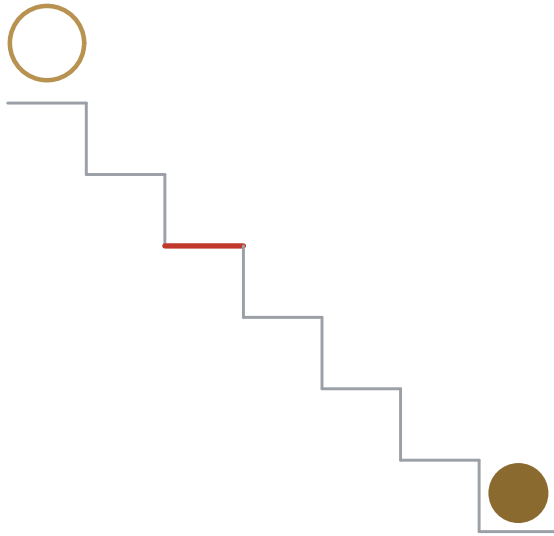
The Cost of Staying

London once poured its sewage into the Thames and paid for it in funerals. Cholera killed more than fourteen thousand Londoners in 1849 and more than ten thousand in 1853, and nothing was built. Then came the hot summer of 1858, when the river smelled so bad that Parliament itself could not sit. The law went through in weeks. The cost of staying, it turns out, is very motivating once it reaches the people who vote.

Where you are now is never free. It charges rent every month, in money, energy, health, or sleep. We tell ourselves that not fixing a problem saves the cost of fixing it. We pay anyway, keep paying, and never get it fixed.

The move. Price the gap before you price the bridge. What is staying here costing you each month, in dollars or in sleep?

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**Dream, define, declare, decide,
design, daily, deliver.**

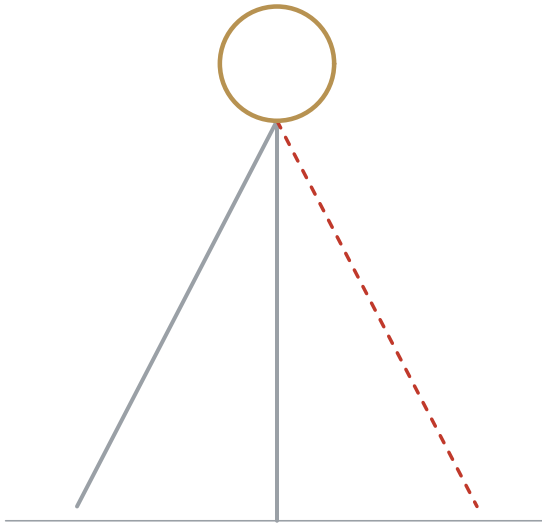
From Dream to Delivery

A dream passes through seven stages on its way to being real. Dream it, define it, declare it, decide it, design it, break it into daily work, and deliver. Most people skip stage three, which is the one where you tell somebody. A dream told to no one costs nothing to drop. A dream told to people whose opinion stings to lose puts you on the hook, and the hook is useful.

After a flood drowned 1,836 people in 1953, the Netherlands wrote its goal into law: hold the coast against the storm that comes once in ten thousand years. The building took four decades. The last great barrier opened in 1997. Declared things have a way of getting built.

The move. Walk your goal down the stairs, from picture to detail to a witness to today's work. A dream still sitting on the top step is entertainment.

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The complete kit. Missing any one sinks it.

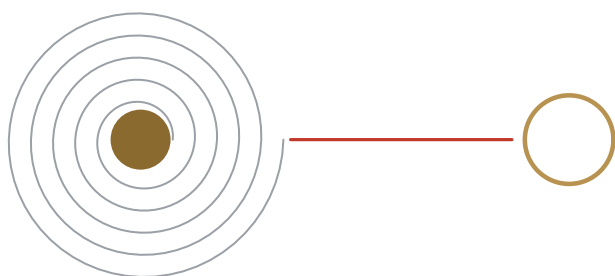
Plan, Paradigm, Knowledge

In 1845 two British ships left for the Northwest Passage with 134 men, three years of canned food, steam engines, and a written plan from the Admiralty. They had a plan, and they had confidence by the boatload. What they did not have was the know-how to live in that place. Every man who stayed with the ships died. The wrecks turned up in 2014 and 2016, close to where the Inuit had said they were all along.

Winning takes three legs. A plan, the belief that the plan is possible, and the specific knowledge to carry it out. Two legs make a very confident stool that falls over.

The move. When something stalls, check the three legs one at a time before you change tactics. The missing one is usually obvious once you look.

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A full day is not a moved life.

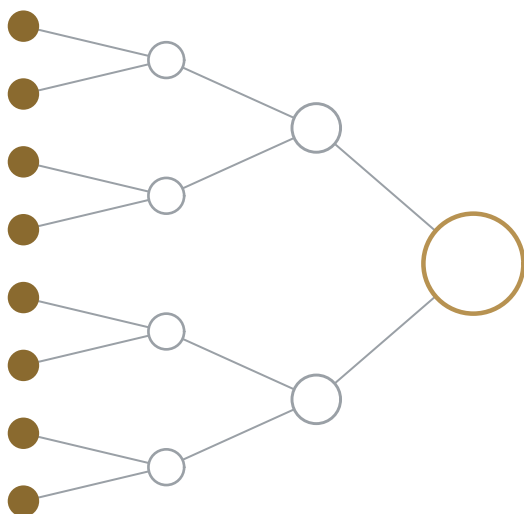
Busyness Is Not Business

In March 1942, US Army engineers started cutting a road from British Columbia to Alaska. More than ten thousand soldiers worked on it. By the end of October, about 1,680 miles of road existed that had not existed in the spring. I am sure they were busy. That is not what anyone remembers. Nobody asks how full their calendars were.

The busiest people you know often produce a beautifully managed pile of tasks and nothing else. Activity is not the measure. The measure is whether today took a chip out of a target that sits thirty days to a year away.

The move. Change your evening question from 'Was I busy?' to 'Which target got smaller today, and by how much?'

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From the goal, backward through the math, down to today.

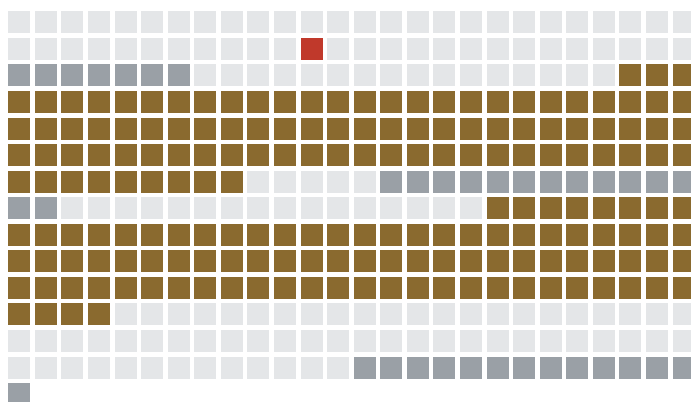
Reverse-Engineer the Target

Hoover Dam needed about 3.25 million cubic yards of concrete. Working backward from the finished dam, the engineers found a small problem. Poured in one piece, it would take 125 years to cool and would crack itself apart. So they poured it in separate columns with chilled water running through pipes inside. It was handed over two years early. All of that came from doing the division before the pouring.

A dream is a number you have not divided yet. Take the result you want and work back. How many sales, so how many conversations, so how many calls, so how many per day? Use honest, modest rates. The daily number is usually shockingly small and completely non-negotiable.

The move. Do the division for your next 30-day target. Then carry out the daily number, not the dream.

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**One map, from the whole year
down to today.**

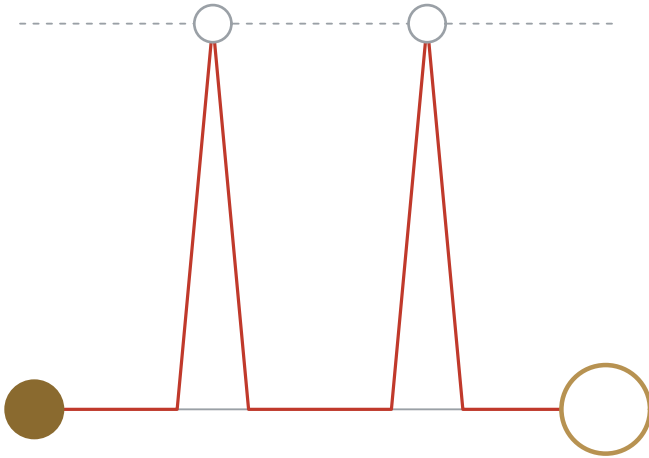
The War Map

The Empire State Building went up at four and a half stories a week. The site had nowhere to stack materials, so every delivery was timed to the day it was needed. It opened ahead of schedule and about nine million dollars under budget, which in construction is roughly as common as a unicorn. Nobody on that site woke up wondering what to do. The drawing had decided weeks earlier.

Put your whole year on one visible map. Block the dead days first, then the build time, then the action window, then the daily quotas. Mornings are then for doing, not deciding. A year laid out in days also tells you something sobering. It is much smaller than it feels.

The move. Look at the map before the inbox. Revise it only at a scheduled review, every sixty to ninety days.

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Strategy at altitude, action on the ground.

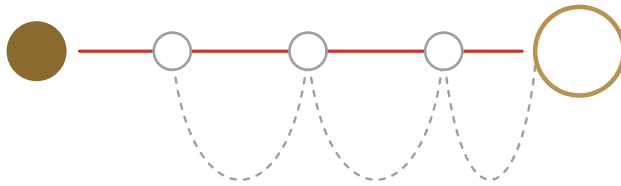
Fly High, Strike Low

In 1802 a surveyor named William Lambton measured a line near Madras with a hundred-foot steel chain, one length at a time, under tents so the sun would not stretch the steel. Seven and a half miles took him 57 days. It is hard to picture more ground-level work. But from that one line, triangles carried the measurement 1,500 miles north, and in 1852 the survey worked out which mountain was the highest on earth.

You need both views. Live only on the ground and you march in energetic circles. Live only in the sky and you never march at all. The rare skill is switching cleanly between them.

The move. Schedule the two views apart. Ground view daily. Altitude briefly each week and fully every sixty to ninety days. Never both at once.

175



**A plan for when they don't do
what you hoped.**

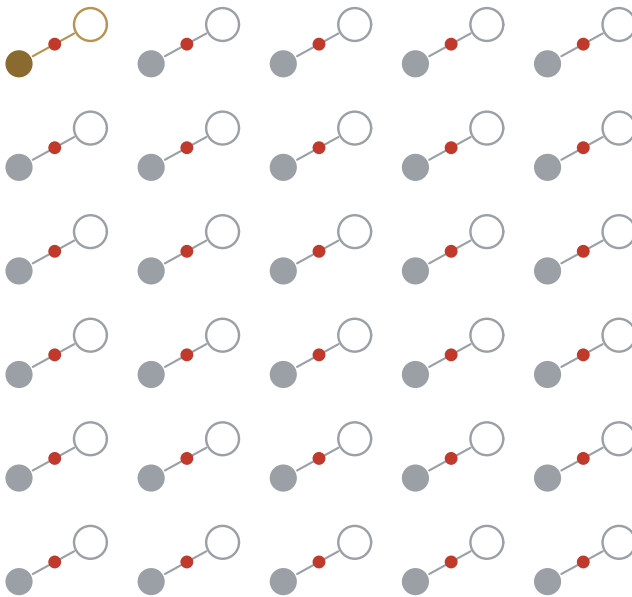
Build the Contingency

When the Golden Gate Bridge was built, the chief engineer, Joseph Strauss, hung a safety net beneath it. No bridge had carried that expense before. It caught nineteen men, who named themselves the Halfway to Hell Club, which tells you something about ironworkers.

The net was not perfect. In February 1937 a scaffold tore through it and ten men died. But nineteen men went home because someone asked 'what happens when?' before it happened. A plan that only works if everyone does what you hoped is not a plan. It is a wish with stages.

The move. For each step of what you are building, ask in advance: what happens when they don't? Build the answer before you launch.

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Vision, mission, principles. The DNA everything copies.

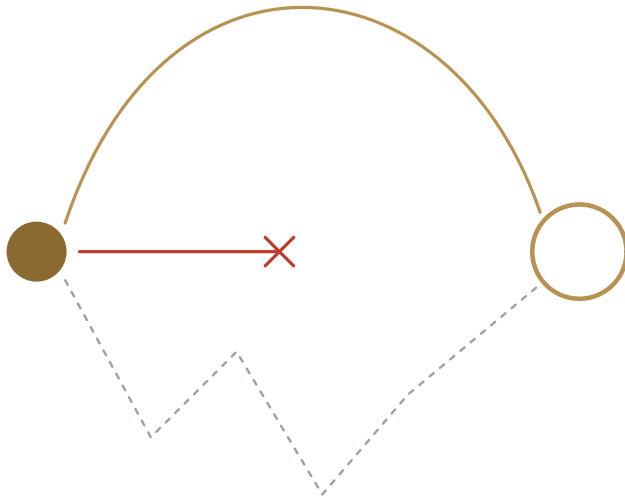
Write the Source Code

Isambard Kingdom Brunel built the Great Western Railway with its rails seven feet apart. It rode better than everybody else's track. It was also different from everybody else's track, and in 1846 the law sided with everybody else. Undoing that one early decision took until 1892, when about 4,200 men converted the last 171 miles in a single weekend.

Early choices get copied into everything that comes after, including the ones you would like back. Your vision, mission, and principles are the source code of whatever you are building. Every hire, product, and habit copies them. And if you wrote nothing down, whatever was lying around gets copied instead.

The move. Before you grow, write the three. The future you see, how you will get there, and the truths you work by. Edit them rarely. Reread them constantly.

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**The vision names the destination,
never the vehicle.**

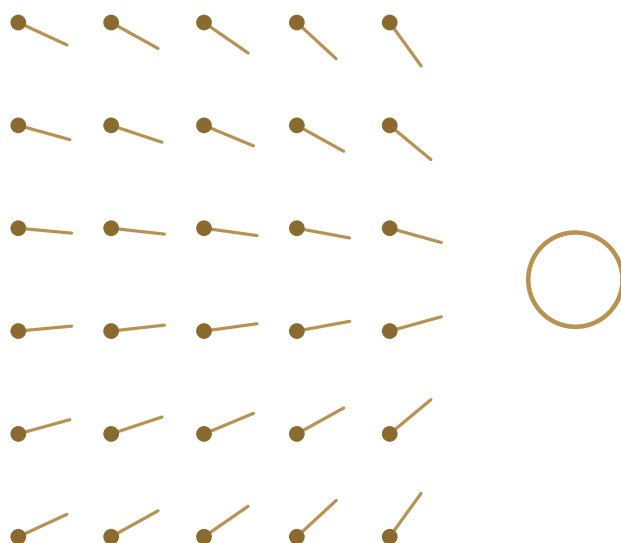
Fix the What, Free the How

Ferdinand de Lesseps had dug the Suez Canal at sea level, so he insisted Panama be dug the same way. He was a man in love with his method. His company dug from 1881, lost more than twenty-two thousand lives to disease and landslides, and went bankrupt in 1889, ruining about 800,000 small investors. The Americans later built it with locks that lift ships to a lake eighty-five feet up. It opened in 1914. Same vision. Different how.

A vision is the big future you intend to make real, and it should say nothing about method. Tie it to a how and it dies with that how. And if you are going to think at all, think big. The size of the vision sets the ceiling for everything under it.

The move. Write the vision as what exists when the work is done. Let plans and tactics be replaced without grief.

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**One sentence anyone can steer
by, including you.**

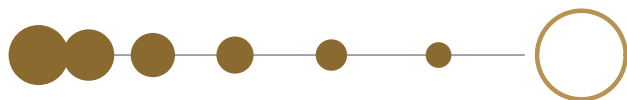
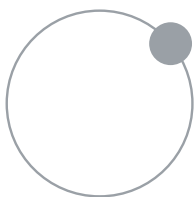
The Mission Is the How

The 1953 Everest expedition had more than four hundred men and one sentence: put two men on the summit and bring them back. Everyone else existed to place them there. So when the first pair reached the South Summit with their oxygen failing, they turned around at twenty past one, and nobody needed a meeting about it. Three days later Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay reached the top.

A mission turns the vision into today. Its test is simple and a little brutal. One reading should tell anyone, including you, what to do next. A vague mission makes every person's guess the strategy.

The move. Write it in one sentence sharp enough to choose with. If a newcomer reads it and still asks 'So what do we do?', it is not finished.

260



**One question separates motion
from progress.**

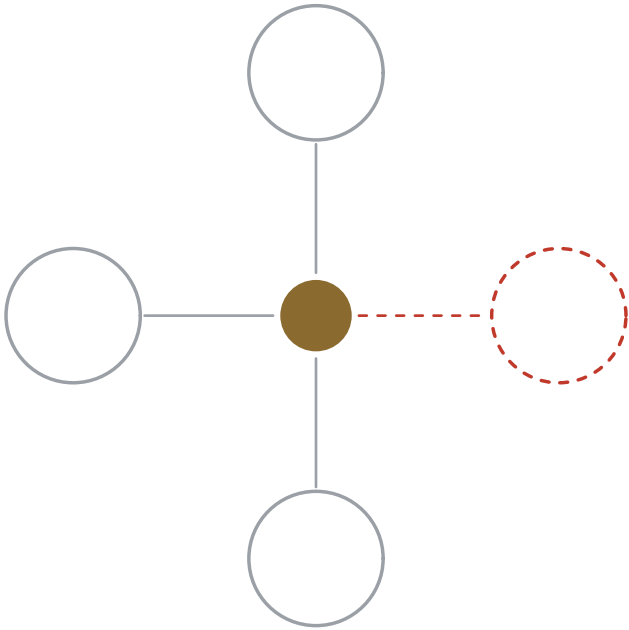
Does It Make the Boat Go Faster

Ships kept running aground on the silt bar at the mouth of the Mississippi. The fix was dredging. Then the river filled it back in, and the dredging started again. In 1875 James Eads offered Congress a different deal. He would build jetties at his own expense to squeeze the current until the river scoured its own channel, and be paid only if it held. It held. New Orleans rose from the ninth busiest port in America to the second.

Dredging is maintenance. It keeps you afloat and adds no speed. Jetties are performance. The trap is that maintenance feels exactly like work, and a boat that only gets maintained is standing still in a moving race.

The move. Each evening ask two things. Is the maintenance done? And what made the boat go faster? Then eliminate, automate, or delegate the first so your hours land on the second.

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**Process, paradigm, community,
mentorship.**

The Four Engines of Change

Roald Amundsen spent two winters in the Arctic living beside the Netsilik Inuit. He did not lecture them on how things were done in Norway. He took up their reindeer-skin clothing, their igloos, and their way of driving dogs. In 1906 his ship became the first through the Northwest Passage, and in 1911 the same skins and dogs took him to the South Pole.

He had a process that worked, a mind willing to be changed, a community where surviving the cold was ordinary, and teachers who were ahead of him. Those are the four engines of any big change. Notice that willpower is not on the list. Willpower is what you reach for when one of the four is missing, and it tends to run out by Thursday.

The move. Before a major change, check all four. A proven process, a new way of seeing, a room where your goal is normal, and someone ahead of you to ask. Whichever is missing is your first project.



That is the first root.

You now know more about change than most plans ever find out. There is a start, a finish, and a distance, and you are the one holding the tape measure.

Next comes Natural Law, which opens with bad news that turns out to be good news. Reality does not care about your opinion. This means it can be relied upon.

The other thirteen roots are in the complete book, which is open to members of our research group. Join us at jeanlouishardy.com.

Reading this changed nothing

I say that with affection.

You have just read a book of principles, and the awkward truth about principles is that reading them does nothing at all. A law you have only read is a rumor. A law you have tried on a Tuesday, in your own business or your own kitchen, is yours.

This whole book stands on one of its own roots. The answer is in the test, not in your head. So it would be strange to end by asking you to agree with me. I would much rather you went and found out.

That is what our research group is for. It lives on Skool. We take the Laws of Change out of the book and into real companies and real homes, and then we compare notes on what happened. Some of it works the first time. Some of it works the fourth time. All of it is more fun in company. Another root in this book says that nothing great is built alone, so I am only following instructions.

So here is the one thing I will ask of you. Join our research group. You already have the hard part, which is a gap worth closing and the nerve to look at it. Come and find out what you can do with it.



Join our research group.

This is where we explore how to apply the Laws of Change, in real companies and real homes, and compare notes on what held up.

The complete book is open to members, with all 381 principles, every story, and every source.

New here? There is free training at the same address to get you started.

Join us at

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Jean Louis Hardy